DELHI:
ADVANTAGE AAP
PG 8

UPFRONT

JHARKHAND:
BABU IN THE
DOCK PG 11



SWEET SUCCESS CM Adityanath with his deputy CMs and others after the poll results, May 13

SUMIT KUMAR

LOCAL BODY POLLS

IT'S BRAND YOGI IN UP

By Prashant Srivastava

The results of the local body elections in Uttar Pradesh prove yet again that the Yogi factor remains strong in the state. With the chief minister himself leading the campaign, addressing 50 rallies in 13 days, the BJP swept the urban areas, winning all 17 mayoral seats, and improved its performance in the nagar panchayat parishads (191 out of 544 seats) and nagar palika parishads (87 of 199 seats). The three-tiered local body elections were held in two phases in the first half of May. As votes from a 53 per cent turnout (of the state's 43.2 million eligible voters) were counted, the Karnataka results—declared the same day—might as well have been happening in another galaxy. UP was in its own orbit.

The Samajwadi Party (SP), the main opposition party, drew a blank in the mayoral seats but managed to get chairperson posts in 35 nagar palikas and 78 nagar panchayats. The BSP won 15 nagar palikas and 37 nagar panchayats, and the Congress four and 14, respectively. The rest went to smaller parties and independents.

The elections were being held just weeks after the sensational killing of mafia don-turned-neta Atiq Ahmed and his brother Ashraf while they were in police custody. Yogi carried the 'making UP safe' narrative into the polls—his "*Mafia ko mitti mein mila denge* (I'll grind the mafia into dust)" remark becoming his central plank. The fight against crime continued on the ground too; another dreaded gangster, Anil Dujana, was killed in a police encounter in Meerut a few days